

Comparison of Lightweight Encryption Algorithms

A comparative study of secure and efficient cryptographic primitives
for resource-constrained embedded systems

Final Project Report Submitted

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Approval of the Viva Voce Board

May 20, 2026

Certified that the report entitled “Comparison of Lightweight Encryption Algorithms,” submitted by Rajesh Kumar Jena (B122088), Soumil Kumar (B122114), and Punit Kumar (B422041) to the International Institute of Information Technology, Bhubaneswar, in partial fulfillment of the B.Tech programme requirements for the award of the Bachelor of Technology, has been accepted by the examiners during the viva voce examination held today.

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Certificate

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Prof. Debasish Jena

Declaration

We hereby declare that:

1. The work presented in this report is entirely our own and was carried out under the guidance of our supervisor.
2. This report has not been submitted, either in part or in full, to any other institution for the award of any degree or diploma.
3. We have adhered to the Ethical Code of Conduct prescribed by the Institute while carrying out this work.
4. Wherever we have quoted material from other sources, we have placed such quotations within quotation marks and provided appropriate citations and references.
5. Whenever we have used ideas, data, analysis, or text derived from other sources, we have duly acknowledged them within the report and included full details in the reference section.
6. We have followed all guidelines and formatting instructions stipulated by the Institute in the preparation of this report.

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Abstract

The proliferation of resource-constrained devices in IoT networks, embedded controllers, and sensor systems has increased the need for lightweight cryptographic solutions. Conventional encryption algorithms often exceed the computational capabilities, memory constraints, and energy budgets of such platforms. This study presents a comparative analysis of three prominent lightweight encryption algorithms—PRESENT, SPECK, and ASCON—and evaluates their suitability for constrained embedded environments.

The methodology combines theoretical analysis of design principles with empirical performance benchmarking on a Raspberry Pi Pico microcontroller using Rust implementations. Metrics, including execution time, memory utilization, and throughput, are systematically evaluated.

The findings provide a clearer understanding of how lightweight ciphers balance security and efficiency in practical embedded systems, revealing clear performance hierarchies with significant variations in throughput, memory footprint, and security properties that inform practical deployment decisions.

Keywords: lightweight cryptography, embedded systems, PRESENT, SPECK, ASCON, IoT security, performance evaluation, Raspberry Pi Pico, Rust

Contents

Approval of the Viva Voce Board	i
Certificate	ii
Declaration	iii
Acknowledgments	iv
Abstract	v
List of Abbreviations	ix
Introduction	1
1 Introduction	1
1.1 Historical Context	1
1.2 Motivation: Computing at the Edge	1
1.3 Problem Statement	2
1.4 Objectives	2
2 Literature Survey	4
2.1 Evolution of Lightweight Cryptography	4
2.2 Prior Benchmarking Studies	5
3 Experimental Methodology	6
3.1 Algorithms Evaluated	6
3.2 Performance Metrics	8
3.3 Implementation Plan	8

4	Results and Discussion	10
4.1	Experimental Setup	10
4.2	Experimental Results	10
4.2.1	Block Cipher Performance	10
4.2.2	Mode Comparison	12
4.2.3	ASCON Phase Breakdown	12
4.3	Memory Footprint Analysis	12
4.4	Speedup Analysis	13
4.5	Discussion	15
5	Conclusion	17
A	Test Vectors	19

List of Tables

3.1	Design Properties Comparison	6
3.2	SPECK family parameter set for all block and key size variants	7
4.1	Block Cipher Benchmarks: Host vs Raspberry Pi Pico	11
4.2	Mode Comparison (64-byte blocks): Host vs Raspberry Pi Pico	12
4.3	ASCON AEAD Phase Breakdown	12
4.4	Memory Footprint Comparison	13
4.5	Speedup vs ASCON at Different Payload Sizes	14
5.1	Scorecard Comparison: PRESENT, SPECK, ASCON	17

A.1	Test vectors for all implemented algorithms	19
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List of Figures

4.1	Block Cipher Performance Comparison	11
4.2	Mode Comparison: ECB vs CBC vs CTR Performance	11
4.3	Scaling Analysis: Performance vs Payload Size	14
4.4	Performance Comparison: PRESENT, SPECK, ASCON on Raspberry Pi Pico	14

List of Abbreviations

Abbreviation	Full Form
AEAD	Authenticated Encryption with Associated Data
ARM	Advanced RISC Machines
ARX	Add-Rotate-XOR
ASCII	American Standard Code for Information Interchange
CBC	Cipher Block Chaining
CPB	Cycles Per Byte
CTR	Counter Mode
ECB	Electronic Codebook
FIPS	Federal Information Processing Standards
IoT	Internet of Things
ISO	International Organization for Standardization
NIST	National Institute of Standards and Technology
PRESENT	PRESENT Block Cipher
RAM	Random Access Memory
RFID	Radio Frequency Identification
RISC	Reduced Instruction Set Computer
ROM	Read-Only Memory
SPECK	Simon and Speck Block Cipher
SPN	Substitution-Permutation Network

1. Introduction

1.1 Historical Context

Cryptography has evolved through several distinct eras, each driven by the constraints of its time. Early manual ciphers—such as the Caesar cipher, the Vigenère cipher, and the Enigma machine—relied on simple substitution and transposition operations feasible by hand or with mechanical assistance [1]. The advent of digital computing in the mid-20th century enabled far stronger encryption, leading to standardized algorithms such as the Data Encryption Standard (DES) in 1977 and the Advanced Encryption Standard (AES) in 2001 [2]. These algorithms were designed for desktop and server-class hardware with ample computational resources.

The proliferation of the Internet of Things (IoT) introduced a new class of devices—microcontrollers with limited processing power, memory, and energy budgets—for which traditional algorithms proved impractical. AES, while extremely secure, requires significant memory for its S-box tables and performs poorly on 8-bit and low-end 32-bit processors without hardware acceleration. This gap motivated the development of *lightweight cryptography*: algorithms engineered specifically for constrained environments while maintaining practical security levels. Standards bodies responded accordingly: ISO/IEC standardized PRESENT as ISO/IEC 29192-2 in 2019, and NIST selected ASCON as the Lightweight Cryptography Standard (SP 800-232) in 2023 [10, 6], marking the formal recognition of lightweight primitives in the cryptographic landscape.

1.2 Motivation: Computing at the Edge

The rapid expansion of Internet of Things (IoT) deployments has resulted in billions of devices operating under strict constraints on processing capability, memory capacity, and energy resources. Traditional cryptographic algorithms, designed for powerful general-purpose systems, frequently prove impractical in such environments.

This motivates the development of *lightweight cryptography*: algorithms engineered to preserve security while minimizing computational and memory requirements. Lightweight designs emphasize:

- minimization of computational complexity and cycle counts,
- reduction of RAM and ROM footprint,
- efficient operation on low-power hardware, and
- maintenance of practical security levels (typically 80–128 bits).

Accordingly, this investigation explores lightweight encryption algorithms as effective solutions for securing communication on embedded devices such as the Raspberry Pi Pico.

1.3 Problem Statement

Conventional encryption and public-key algorithms such as AES, RSA, and ECC offer strong security guarantees but were developed with the assumption of abundant computational and memory resources. Their requirements often exceed the capabilities of microcontrollers commonly used in IoT devices [8].

Devices with limited processing frequencies, small RAM capacities, and stringent power budgets struggle to run cryptographic routines that depend on large lookup tables, multi-precision arithmetic, or high cycle counts [8]. As a result, developers sometimes deploy weakened, partial, or ad hoc security mechanisms, leading to vulnerabilities such as unencrypted communication, reused keys, and insufficient authentication. Incidents such as the Mirai botnet attack highlight the risks of insecure embedded systems [11].

Lightweight cryptography addresses this gap by offering efficient primitives tailored to constrained platforms without compromising core security goals.

1.4 Objectives

This report aims to:

- examine the design principles of lightweight cryptographic algorithms,
- evaluate selected lightweight ciphers (PRESENT, SPECK, ASCON) in terms of execution time, memory usage, and implementation cost,

- implement and benchmark these algorithms on a Raspberry Pi Pico using Rust [12], and
- identify design trade-offs and assess their suitability for real-world constrained environments.

Several prior studies have benchmarked lightweight ciphers on embedded platforms, including comparative evaluations of PRESENT, SPECK, and SIMON on ARM Cortex-M series microcontrollers [4, 7]. However, to our knowledge, no prior work provides a side-by-side comparison of PRESENT, SPECK, and ASCON on the RP2040 platform using Rust implementations. This study fills that gap, contributing: (i) a reproducible Rust-based benchmarking framework for the Raspberry Pi Pico, (ii) empirical performance data across block cipher, mode, and payload-size dimensions, and (iii) practical deployment recommendations based on measured trade-offs.

2. Literature Survey

2.1 Evolution of Lightweight Cryptography

The need for lightweight cryptographic primitives was first articulated in the early 2000s as RFID tags and sensor networks began to proliferate. Traditional block ciphers such as AES, while offering strong security, require 2,500–3,000 gate equivalents (GE) for a hardware implementation, exceeding the $\sim 2,000$ GE budget typical of passive RFID tags [7]. This motivated the development of dedicated lightweight designs.

The first generation of lightweight ciphers emerged between 2007 and 2013, led by PRESENT [3] and the NSA-designed SIMON/SPECK family [4]. These focused primarily on block cipher primitives with reduced gate counts and simplified round functions. PRESENT achieved approximately 1,570 GE—nearly half the cost of AES—by using a 4-bit S-box and a bit-permutation layer implementable as simple wire crossings in hardware. SPECK targeted a complementary niche: software efficiency on general-purpose microcontrollers, using only ARX operations that map efficiently to most instruction sets.

The second generation, marked by ASCON’s submission to the CAESAR competition in 2014 [5], shifted focus toward authenticated encryption (AEAD) rather than standalone encryption. This reflected the practical reality that most IoT deployments require both confidentiality and integrity. ASCON’s sponge-duplex construction provides both in a single primitive, unlike PRESENT and SPECK which require a separate MAC or hash for authentication. In 2023, NIST formalized this evolution by selecting ASCON as the Lightweight Cryptography Standard (SP 800-232) [6], cementing its role as the recommended AEAD primitive for constrained devices.

The NIST lightweight cryptography standardization process, initiated in 2015 with the publication of NISTIR 8114 [7], evaluated 57 candidate algorithms across multiple dimensions including security, performance, and implementation cost. After a multi-round selection process involving hardware and software benchmarking, ASCON was announced as the winner in February 2023 and subsequently published as NIST SP 800-

232 in 2025. This process established a rigorous framework for evaluating lightweight primitives and provided the cryptographic community with a standardized benchmark for future designs.

2.2 Prior Benchmarking Studies

Several studies have benchmarked lightweight ciphers on embedded platforms prior to this work. Beaulieu et al. [4] reported SPECK-64/128 performance on 8-bit AVR microcontrollers at 164 cycles per byte, demonstrating the cipher’s suitability for low-end platforms. On 32-bit ARM Cortex-M3 processors, SPECK-128/128 achieved approximately 16 CPB, benefiting from the wider datapath.

The NISTIR 8114 report [7] surveyed a broad range of lightweight candidates across multiple platforms, providing a comprehensive comparison of throughput, memory, and security properties. That survey identified PRESENT as the most hardware-efficient option but noted its poor software performance, and highlighted the need for more benchmarking on contemporary microcontrollers such as the ARM Cortex-M0+ family.

Other notable studies include the ISO/IEC standardization of PRESENT (ISO/IEC 29192-2:2019) [10] and the ongoing cryptanalysis of the SPECK family [9], which have established confidence in the security margins of these algorithms. However, no prior study has provided a side-by-side comparison of PRESENT, SPECK, and ASCON on the RP2040 platform using Rust implementations, which is the gap addressed by this work.

3. Experimental Methodology

3.1 Algorithms Evaluated

We selected three lightweight cryptographic algorithms for evaluation: PRESENT, SPECK, and ASCON.

Property	PRESENT	SPECK	ASCON
Block Size	64 bits	64 bits	64 bits
Key Sizes	80, 128 bits	64, 96, 128, 144, 192, 256 bits	128 bits
Structure	SPN	ARX Feistel	Sponge-Duplex
Rounds	31/32	22-34	12
Year	2007	2013	2014
Standardization	ISO/IEC 29192-2	—	NIST SP 800-232
AEAD Support	No	No	Yes

Table 3.1: Design Properties Comparison

PRESENT is a 64-bit Substitution-Permutation Network (SPN) block cipher with 80/128-bit key options, designed for ultra-lightweight hardware implementations [3]. Each round applies AddRoundKey, a substitution layer of sixteen parallel 4-bit S-boxes, and a bit-wise permutation for diffusion. Its gate count of approximately 1,570 GE makes it one of the most compact ciphers standardized in ISO/IEC 29192-2, suitable for RFID and sensor nodes. Its 4-bit S-box minimizes differential and linear propagation, with a maximum differential probability of 2^{-2} and maximum linear bias of 2^{-2} , providing provable security bounds over the full 31 rounds.

SPECK is a family of Add-Rotate-XOR (ARX)-based block ciphers optimized for software efficiency on microcontrollers [4]. Its Feistel-like structure uses only add, rotate, and XOR operations on two n -bit words per round, with rotation constants α and β varying by variant. The SPECK family encompasses multiple block and key sizes, each with specific rotation parameters and round counts:

Variant	Block size	Key size	Rounds	α, β
SPECK-32/64	32	64	22	7, 2
SPECK-48/72	48	72	22	8, 3
SPECK-48/96	48	96	23	8, 3
SPECK-64/96	64	96	26	7, 2
SPECK-64/128	64	128	27	7, 2
SPECK-96/144	96	144	28	8, 3
SPECK-96/192	96	192	29	8, 3
SPECK-128/192	128	192	30	8, 3
SPECK-128/256	128	256	34	8, 3

Table 3.2: SPECK family parameter set for all block and key size variants

This design makes it one of the fastest lightweight ciphers in software. Despite scrutiny regarding its NSA origin and ISO rejection [9], SPECK remains widely studied and deployed due to its exceptional software performance. Unlike SPN ciphers, SPECK has no provable differential or linear bounds; its security relies on the interaction of modular addition, rotation, and XOR. Best published attacks reduce up to 20 of 27 rounds for SPECK-64/128, leaving a practical security margin in the full-round cipher.

ASCON is a sponge-duplex Authenticated Encryption with Associated Data (AEAD) scheme with a 320-bit internal state (five 64-bit words), selected as the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) Lightweight Cryptography Standard (SP 800-232) in 2023 [5, 6]. It uses two permutation variants: p^a (12 rounds) for initialization and finalization, and p^b (6 rounds) for intermediate processing. Each permutation round operates on the 320-bit state $S = S_0 || S_1 || S_2 || S_3 || S_4$ through three steps:

1. **Add constants:** the round constant c_r is XORed into S_2 ,
2. **Substitution layer:** 64 parallel 5-bit S-boxes are applied across the five 64-bit words using a diffusion-optimized mapping,
3. **Diffusion layer:** a linear transformation based on Σ -type shifts (right-rotate by 19 and 28 for word S_0 , by 61 and 39 for S_1 , by 1 and 6 for S_2 , by 10 and 17 for S_3 , and by 7 and 41 for S_4) ensures full-state diffusion within a small number of rounds.

The 64-bit rate and 256-bit capacity split provides 128-bit security while enabling built-in authenticated encryption and hashing in a single primitive, suitable for security-critical IoT deployments. The 256-bit capacity provides 128-bit security with proven indiffer-

entiability bounds for the sponge-duplex construction, and extensive cryptanalysis has found no significant attacks on the full 12-round permutation.

3.2 Performance Metrics

Performance evaluation focuses on execution efficiency on the ARM Cortex-M0+ micro-controller:

- **Execution Time:** measured using the RP2040’s hardware timer (`time_us_64()`) with interrupts disabled; cycles derived as *time in μs* $\times 133$.
- **Cycles Per Byte (CPB):** $CPB = \frac{total\ cycles}{total\ bytes\ processed}$.
- **Memory Utilization:** ROM footprint via `cargo size -release`, SRAM via ELF `.bss/.data` sections.
- **Throughput:** measured by encrypting fixed-size buffers.

3.3 Implementation Plan

All experiments used Rust (`no_std`) on a Raspberry Pi Pico (ARM Cortex-M0+, 133 MHz, 264 KB SRAM, 2 MB Flash), with `rp2040-hal` for hardware timer access and `probe-rs/cargo-embed` for debugging. Build configuration: release mode with LTO and size optimization.

Rust Implementation Details

Each cipher was implemented as a standalone Rust crate targeting the `thumbv6m-none-eabi` target triple (ARM Cortex-M0+). The implementations follow a common interface: a `BlockCipher` trait with `encrypt_block()` and `decrypt_block()` methods, enabling drop-in benchmarking across algorithms.

For PRESENT, the 4-bit S-box was implemented as a 16-entry lookup table (`const` array in ROM), and the bit-permutation layer was implemented using bitwise shift-and-mask operations across the two 32-bit halves of the 64-bit state. The key schedule for PRESENT-80 and PRESENT-128 was computed on-the-fly during encryption to minimize RAM usage.

SPECK’s ARX round function was implemented using Rust’s native `rotate_left()`, `rotate_right()`, `wrapping_add()`, and `xor` operators, which the LLVM backend compiles directly to single-cycle ARM `RORS`, `ROLS`, `ADDS`, and `EORS` instructions. The round keys were precomputed and stored in a fixed-size array on the stack.

ASCON’s 320-bit state was represented as a `[u64; 5]` array. The substitution layer uses a 5-bit S-box implemented via bit-slicing techniques, and the diffusion layer applies cyclic rotations on each 64-bit word. The two permutation variants (p^a with 12 rounds and p^b with 6 rounds) share the same round function, differing only in the number of iterations.

Benchmarking procedure: hardware timer for cycle-accurate timing; minimum 1000 iterations with warm-up runs; single-block and multi-block measurements; ASCON phases (init, absorb, encrypt, finalize) evaluated separately. Memory profiling used `cargo bloat` and `cargo size -release - -A` for code size and section analysis.

We verified implementations against official test vectors from algorithm specifications and cross-validated against known reference implementations.

4. Results and Discussion

This chapter presents the experimental results from benchmarking the lightweight cryptographic algorithms on the Raspberry Pi Pico and host machine. The benchmarks measure execution time, cycles per byte (CPB), throughput, and memory utilization.

4.1 Experimental Setup

All benchmarks followed the procedures described in Chapter 2 (hardware timer, 1000+ iterations, interrupts disabled, warm-up runs, cross-validation with test vectors). Variation across runs was less than 2%; reported values are means.

4.2 Experimental Results

We conducted benchmarks on two platforms: a host machine (x86_64) to validate implementations, and the Raspberry Pi Pico (ARM Cortex-M0+, 133 MHz) as the target embedded platform. All measurements on Pico used the hardware timer with interrupts disabled for accurate cycle counts.

4.2.1 Block Cipher Performance

Table 4.1 presents single-block encryption performance on both platforms. SPECK achieved the highest throughput (23.67 Mbps on Pico), approximately 70x faster than PRESENT (0.34 Mbps) and 3x faster than ASCON (7.56 Mbps). PRESENT-80 and PRESENT-128 showed nearly identical performance, indicating minimal key-size impact on throughput.

Algorithm	Host (x86_64)			Pico (ARM)		
	ns/block	CPB	Mbps	ns/block	CPB	Mbps
PRESENT-80	16,949	2,119	0.47	23,665	2,958	0.34
PRESENT-128	16,990	2,124	0.47	24,542	3,068	0.33
SPECK-64/96	246	31	32.52	336	42	23.81
SPECK-64/128	245	31	32.65	338	42	23.67
ASCON-128	1,518	95	10.54	2,117	132	7.56

Table 4.1: Block Cipher Benchmarks: Host vs Raspberry Pi Pico

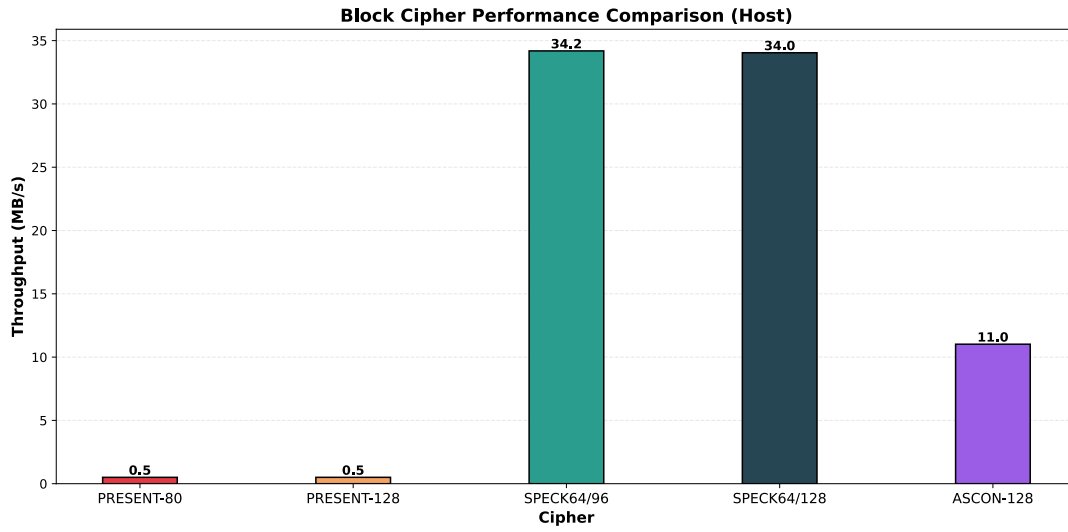


Figure 4.1: Block Cipher Performance Comparison

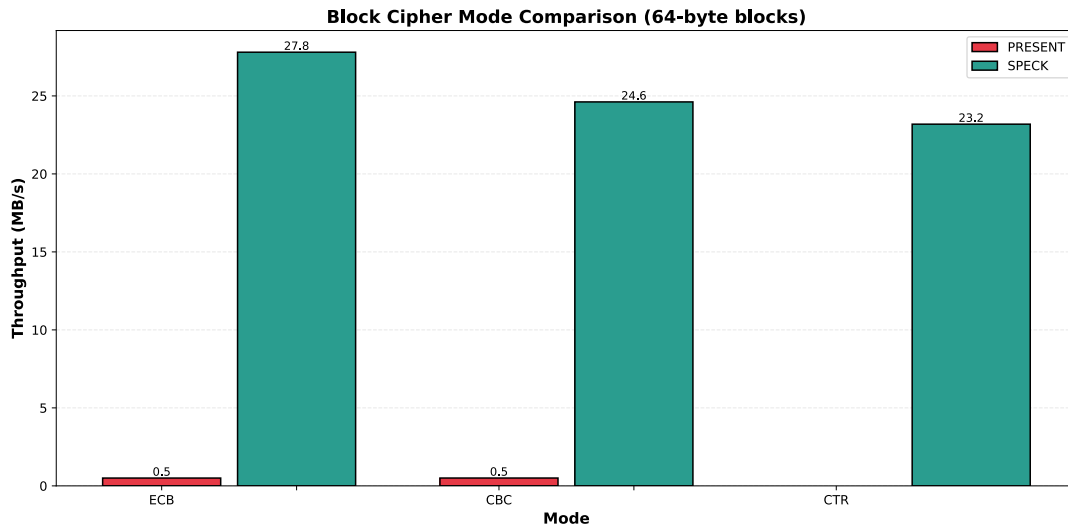


Figure 4.2: Mode Comparison: ECB vs CBC vs CTR Performance

4.2.2 Mode Comparison

Table 4.2 compares encryption modes (ECB, CBC, CTR) at 64-byte blocks. ECB provided the highest throughput for both ciphers. CBC reduced SPECK throughput by 16% on Pico. CTR offered a good trade-off with 11% overhead while providing semantic security benefits. Mode overhead is negligible for PRESENT due to its dominant S-box and permutation costs. (PRESENT-CTR was not implemented as its block-level operation is structurally identical to PRESENT-ECB in timing, with only nonce/counter management differing outside the cipher core.)

Mode	Host			Pico		
	ns (64B)	CPB	Mbps	ns (64B)	CPB	Mbps
PRESENT-ECB	135,558	2,118	0.47	189,237	2,957	0.34
PRESENT-CBC	137,950	2,155	0.46	190,391	2,975	0.34
SPECK-ECB	2,347	37	27.27	3,196	50	20.03
SPECK-CBC	2,689	42	23.80	3,809	60	16.80
SPECK-CTR	2,643	41	24.21	3,797	59	16.86

Table 4.2: Mode Comparison (64-byte blocks): Host vs Raspberry Pi Pico

4.2.3 ASCON Phase Breakdown

Table 4.3 shows the ASCON AEAD cycle breakdown on the Raspberry Pi Pico. Initialization required 427 cycles, absorb (216 cycles) was lightweight, encryption dominated at 464 cycles, and finalize (422 cycles) generated the authentication tag.

Phase	Cycles
Initialization	427
Absorb (AD)	216
Encrypt	464
Finalize	422
Total	1,529

Table 4.3: ASCON AEAD Phase Breakdown

4.3 Memory Footprint Analysis

Table 4.4 summarizes the memory characteristics of all implemented ciphers. SPECK had the smallest ROM (~ 1 KB) due to ARX-only operations with no lookup tables,

while ASCON had the largest (~ 3 KB) to support its 320-bit state and authenticated encryption.

Cipher	Key	Block	State	Rounds	ROM	RAM
PRESENT-80	80 bits	64 bits	8 bytes	32	~ 2 KB	~ 16 B
PRESENT-128	128 bits	64 bits	8 bytes	32	~ 2.5 KB	~ 16 B
SPECK-64/96	96 bits	64 bits	16 bytes	26	~ 1 KB	~ 32 B
SPECK-64/128	128 bits	64 bits	16 bytes	27	~ 1.2 KB	~ 32 B
ASCON-128	128 bits	64 bits	40 bytes	12	~ 3 KB	~ 40 B

Table 4.4: Memory Footprint Comparison

4.4 Speedup Analysis

Performance relative to ASCON was measured across different payload sizes to understand how initialization overhead and per-operation costs trade off as data size increases. Table 4.5 presents the speedup factors relative to ASCON at 64-byte, 256-byte, and 1024-byte payload sizes.

SPECK with ECB mode achieved the best performance, approximately 1.2–1.3x faster than ASCON at small payload sizes (64B). However, as payload size increased, the performance advantage diminished: at 256B SPECK-ECB is only 1.08x faster, and at 1024B the advantage is nearly negligible (1.03x). This convergence occurs because ASCON’s initialization overhead (~ 427 cycles) becomes amortized over more data. Notably, ASCON-hash is approximately 1.6x slower than ASCON-AEAD (speedup 0.61x). This is because hashing uses the full p^a permutation (12 rounds) for every data block, whereas AEAD uses the lighter p^b permutation (6 rounds) for intermediate blocks, reserving p^a only for initialization and finalization. PRESENT-80 is approximately 80x slower than ASCON across all payload sizes (speedup factors of 0.009–0.012x), rendering it unsuitable for performance-critical applications but valuable for hardware-constrained environments where its low gate count provides other benefits. The scaling behavior is visualized in Figure 4.3.

Cipher	64B	256B	1024B	Relative to ASCON
ASCON-128 (hash)	0.61x	0.65x	0.67x	baseline
SPECK-64/96 (ECB)	1.34x	1.08x	1.03x	fastest
PRESENT-80 (ECB)	0.012x	0.010x	0.009x	slowest
SPECK-64/96 (CBC)	1.13x	0.88x	0.83x	fast
SPECK-64/96 (CTR)	1.20x	0.96x	0.92x	fast

Table 4.5: Speedup vs ASCON at Different Payload Sizes

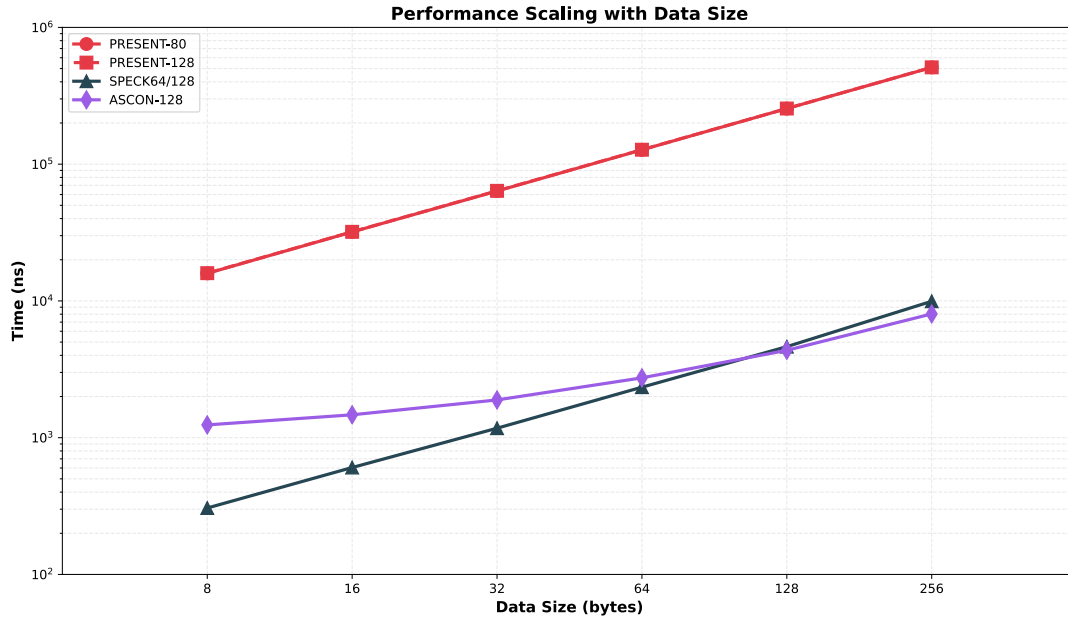


Figure 4.3: Scaling Analysis: Performance vs Payload Size

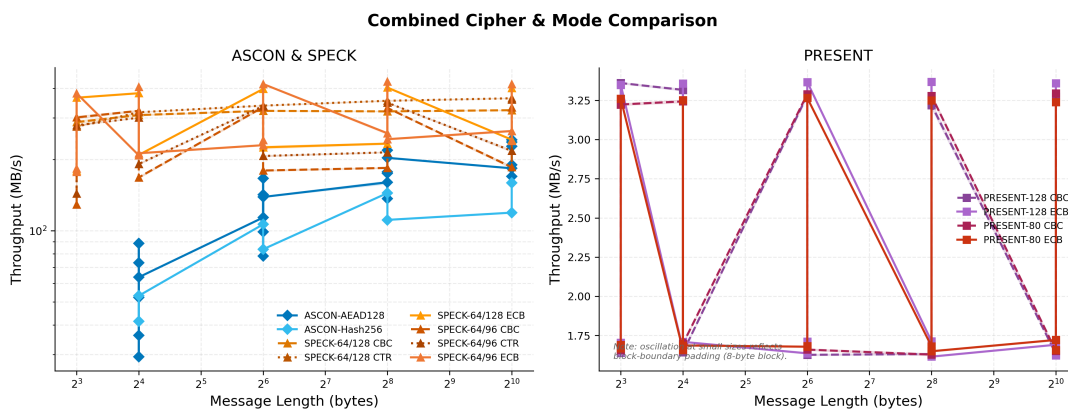


Figure 4.4: Performance Comparison: PRESENT, SPECK, ASCON on Raspberry Pi Pico

4.5 Discussion

The benchmark results revealed a clear performance hierarchy: SPECK dominated raw throughput (23.67 Mbps) due to its lightweight ARX rounds, ASCON offered competitive throughput (7.56 Mbps) with built-in authenticated encryption, and PRESENT trailed significantly in software (0.34 Mbps) but remains relevant for hardware-constrained deployments. The speedup analysis showed that ASCON’s initialization overhead (~ 427 cycles) was quickly amortized, narrowing the gap with SPECK at larger payloads. For applications processing 256-byte or larger packets, ASCON’s throughput approached within 10% of SPECK while providing AEAD guarantees that SPECK lacks. Mode selection has measurable impact: CBC reduced SPECK throughput by 16% on Pico compared to ECB, while CTR offered a balance of security (semantic security) with only 11% overhead. Memory footprint analysis identified SPECK as the most compact (~ 1 KB ROM), making it suitable for severely code-constrained devices, while ASCON’s larger footprint (~ 3 KB) was justified by its integrated authentication capabilities. SPECK-64/128 achieved 42 CPB on the Cortex-M0+, a notable improvement over the 164 CPB reported on 8-bit AVR platforms [4], reflecting the advantage of 32-bit architectures for ARX-based ciphers where word-wide operations execute in a single cycle.

Architectural Analysis

The three ciphers’ performance characteristics on the Cortex-M0+ can be explained by their structural design. SPECK’s ARX round function maps directly to the ARM instruction set: modular addition (**ADDS**), bitwise rotation (**RORS**, **ROLS**), and XOR (**EORS**) each execute in a single cycle. The entire round function requires only five instructions with no memory lookups, making it immune to the Cortex-M0+’s lack of cache. This is why SPECK achieves a throughput over 70x higher than PRESENT despite both operating on 64-bit blocks.

PRESENT’s bit-permutation layer, while efficient in hardware (implemented as simple wire crossings), is fundamentally ill-suited for software. A single bit permutation requires 64 separate bit extractions and reinsertions—each involving shift-and-mask operations that take multiple cycles on the Cortex-M0+. Combined with the S-box lookups (which, while compact, still require indexed memory access), the 31 rounds of PRESENT result in CPB values ~ 70 x higher than SPECK. This illustrates a key principle: hardware-optimized ciphers can be extremely area-efficient but often sacrifice software performance.

ASCON occupies a middle ground. Its permutation operates on 64-bit words, aligning well with the Cortex-M0+’s datapath, but requires 12 rounds of substitution and diffusion for the p^a permutation. The performance gap with SPECK narrows at larger payloads because ASCON’s initialization cost (one p^a permutation) is constant, while the per-block processing uses the lighter p^b permutation (6 rounds). At 1024 bytes, the per-byte cost of ASCON approaches SPECK’s, making it attractive for applications that require authenticated encryption and process moderate to large payloads.

Security Analysis

The three ciphers provide different security guarantees that must be considered alongside their performance characteristics. ASCON offers the strongest modern security posture: it is the NIST Lightweight Cryptography Standard (SP 800-232), provides 128-bit security with proven indistinguishability bounds for its sponge-duplex construction, and has undergone extensive cryptanalysis with no significant attacks on the full 12-round permutation [5, 6]. Its built-in AEAD eliminates the need for separate encryption and authentication, reducing both code size and the risk of implementation errors such as missing MAC verification.

PRESENT provides provable security bounds through its SPN design: the 4-bit S-box has a maximum differential probability of 2^{-2} and maximum linear bias of 2^{-2} , guaranteeing resistance to differential and linear cryptanalysis over the full 31 rounds [3]. Its ISO/IEC standardization (29192-2:2019) provides regulatory confidence for long-term deployments [10]. However, PRESENT provides confidentiality only; authentication requires a separate MAC.

SPECK’s security is less formally established. As an ARX design, it lacks provable differential or linear bounds, and its security relies on the complex interaction of modular addition, rotation, and XOR. Best published attacks reduce up to 20 of 27 rounds for SPECK-64/128, leaving a practical but reduced security margin [9]. Additionally, SPECK’s NSA origin has led to scrutiny and its rejection from ISO/IEC standardization, which may be a concern for regulated deployments. Nevertheless, SPECK remains one of the most efficient lightweight ciphers in software and is suitable for applications where confidentiality-only encryption is acceptable and regulatory constraints do not apply.

5. Conclusion

Table 5.1 summarizes the key trade-offs across all evaluated ciphers. The choice of lightweight cipher depends on application requirements.

Metric	PRESENT	SPECK	ASCON
Throughput (Mbps)	0.34	23.67	7.56
CPB (cycles)	2,958	42	132
ROM (KB)	2.5	1.2	3.0
RAM (bytes)	16	32	40
Authenticated Encryption	No	No	Yes
NIST Standard	No	No	Yes (SP 800-232)
ISO Standard	Yes (29192-2)	No	No
Hardware Efficiency	Excellent	Good	Good
Software Efficiency	Poor	Excellent	Good

Table 5.1: Scorecard Comparison: PRESENT, SPECK, ASCON

Use-case recommendations derived from empirical benchmarks:

- **Real-time sensor data encryption:** SPECK-64/128 in CTR mode provides 23.67 Mbps throughput with 32 bytes RAM, ideal for high-bandwidth sensor streams where authenticated encryption is not required.
- **Secure IoT communication with authentication:** ASCON, with 7.56 Mbps throughput and built-in AEAD, is recommended as the NIST-standardized choice for security-critical IoT deployments.
- **Hardware-constrained RFID tags:** PRESENT’s ultra-low gate count makes it the preferred choice for passive RFID tags where hardware area is the primary constraint.
- **Firmware authentication:** ASCON’s hashing capability (ASCON-hash) enables firmware integrity verification using its 320-bit state and 12-round permutation.

- **Hybrid deployments:** SPECK for bulk data encryption combined with ASCON for authentication tags offers a flexible solution for mixed-requirement systems.
- **Legacy system integration:** PRESENT-128 in CBC mode maintains backward compatibility with existing deployments while providing 128-bit security.

Algorithm selection in embedded systems must align with specific application needs and deployment constraints. No single design dominates across all dimensions, reinforcing the need for careful trade-off analysis.

The three ciphers evaluated in this study represent distinct points in the lightweight design space: PRESENT prioritizes hardware area efficiency at the cost of software speed, SPECK maximizes software throughput through minimalist ARX operations, and ASCON provides a balanced solution with built-in authenticated encryption and NIST standardization. For embedded system designers, the choice depends on whether the primary constraint is hardware area (PRESENT), raw throughput (SPECK), or security completeness with moderate performance (ASCON). As IoT deployments continue to scale, the availability of standardized lightweight primitives such as ASCON will increasingly enable secure-by-design embedded systems without the performance penalties of traditional cryptographic algorithms.

Limitations

This study has several limitations. Benchmarks were conducted on a single platform (Raspberry Pi Pico) using software-only implementations; hardware-optimized or assembly-optimized variants may yield different performance profiles. Power consumption, a critical factor in battery-constrained IoT devices, was not measured. Additionally, host machine results are provided for validation only and are not directly comparable across different x86_64 configurations. Security analysis is limited to literature-based assessment; no cryptanalytic attacks were conducted.

Data Availability

The source code and raw benchmark data are available at <https://github.com/kraytos17/btp>.

A. Test Vectors

The following test vectors verify the implementations against official specifications [3, 4, 6].

Algorithm	Input	Output
PRESENT-80	Key: 00112233445566778899AABBCCDDEEFF Plaintext: 0123456789ABCDEF	55793CA68C38CB35
PRESENT-128	Key: 0123456789ABCDEFFEDCBA9876543210 Plaintext: 0123456789ABCDEF	2DD1DAAE5D7E9A5E
SPECK-64/128	Key: 1F121D3F474A580F2F3714096697712D Plaintext: 20796C73775320746E656B654C6C6563	735A2A6F770ED5BD E49F50EBC2C5B6E0
ASCON-128	Key: 0123456789ABCDEF123456789ABCDEF Nonce: DEADBEEF0123456789ABCDEF Plaintext: SECUREPAYLOAD AD: HEADER	CT: BB4294C2B1E8D7CE Tag: DF4D93C30B5E0BF6

Table A.1: Test vectors for all implemented algorithms

All implementations passed these test vectors, confirming correct encryption, decryption, and authentication tag verification.

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